Personally

By Janet O'Neill

INTRODUCTION

*Once upon a time . . . in an archaic era before social media and the internet, one way to meet people was to post a personal ad in *gasp* the newspaper!*

For those who have never seen a personal ad, they were like your Match.com bio. You said a few words about yourself and let the world know what or who you were looking for.

My grandmother was telling me all about it the other day. She did it lots of times. She says she did it for the thrill. And back then she was ashamed she had to resort to such tactics just to meet someone. She explained:

***GRANDMA:** When you post in a newspaper, you only have 80 characters. If what you say is not really you, if it's shallow, that's OK -- blame the medium. The newspaper personal ad is a dare, it's a risk. A baseball card says more about someone's life than this feeble ad. But that's the way it's gotta be.*

This is the story my grandmother told me . . . Personally by Janet O'Neill

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GRANDMA: (Pg 71-73) My biggest problem had been deciding what to put in the ad. How do you describe yourself in three lines or less? I was determined not to use the same stale lines like, "I like to have fun." Tell me, who doesn't like to have fun? If someone were to say that they didn't like to have fun, that would tell me something. It would tell me to stay away. I settled on a conservative ad:

"33-year-old who likes romance novels, gardening, and charity work seeks a man of similar age and similar interests. Interested in friendship first. We'll see if anything develops."

So I went home and waited for something to develop.

My ad ran in the newspaper for the next five days. What had started as an empowering experience had quickly become one of the most humbling experiences of my life. I got two responses. A newspaper with a circulation of over two million, and I got two responses. The first was a 36- year-old man who was looking for some "love and affection" while his wife

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was out of town, and the second thought Patrick Buchanan was the way of the future. That was it. I tried to laugh it off. Sara took me out for Haagen-Daaz and I kept my chin up. The ad ran for another week.

The next day I got a response. A 31-year-old schoolteacher who loved to travel, read mystery novels, and watch Woody Allen movies. We went out for a drink, which quickly evolved into dinner. . . and a movie. . . and a carriage ride. OK - so it was 20 degrees out and the carriage ride made my legs numb, but his heart was in the right place. He dropped me off, gave me a warm kiss, and said, "I love you." I love you? He's known me for five hours and already he loves me? I've been in love once in my whole life. The next day he called to see if I wanted to go dancing. I said I can't. He asked why. I said, "Because you love me."

I went out with this guy, Jason, the other day. Said he had an important job with a large cooperation. This was kind of true. It seems the company that makes Cool-Whip has an 800 number which you can call and

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ask questions. He was the man who answered the phone. That's right - I'm on a date with the Cool-Whip man! What kind of questions do you think he gets asked all day? "OK, we've got the pie and the Cool-Whip. . . now what do I do?"

The next guy seemed awfully young. He claimed to be 28. He looked younger than some of my friend's children. He picked me up and we went to dinner. At McDonald's. Just me, him, and the Hamburglar. He says he likes to do this because it takes the pressure off the first date. Guess it's hard to feel nervous when you're eating a McRib sandwich. We went to his place, I said, "Hi!" to his mother, and he left to take a phone call. His wallet was just sitting there -- I had to look! I saw his license: 19. Now what do I do? I gave him a peck on the cheek, and politely said, "This isn't going to work. You're just too mature for me." He smiled and said, "That's ok. You aren't the first chick to say that." He called me a chick - it was definitely time to go.

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Cool-Whip man called me yesterday. Said he's been thinking a lot about me. I've got him whipped. Get it? Whipped.

His name was Jimmy. He didn't give a last name. He said second names were for second dates. He took me out for drinks and then we end up at his place. He's crawling on top of me, making me feel like a piece of meat. I say stop. Please stop. He does not force himself on me. Instead, he slaps me. Hard. Then he makes a fist and hits me harder and harder and harder and then he stops and says, "Thanks for the drinks. Here's some cab fare."

The entire concept of the personals baffles me. We ask to be judged by our suitors in three lines or less. We pay to do it. All because the thought of ending up alone is too scary to comprehend. I decided that maybe my ad wasn't good enough, so I jazzed it up a little. Maybe I was attracting the wrong people. No one. So I changed it again. No one. And again. No one. I changed my age, my religion, my hair color. No one.

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And the more that I degraded myself by going out with these losers, the more desperate I got. I laughed at jokes that weren't funny. I went to bars that made my skin crawl. I slept with men who left in the middle of the night and referred to me as a "good piece of a**." I cried.

Now I find myself at my friend Sarah's dinner party. I'm sitting with eight other people: four couples and me. I then realize that it may always be this way: an odd number of people, X number of couples plus me. I find that because of this, I often sit at the head of the table since I don't have someone to sit next to. I guess that could make me feel important, but I know that I'm in the spotlight for the wrong reason.

Just once, I wish that I had someone to introduce to others. Just once I wish that I had someone to date, to love, to fight with, to go home to my parents with. Sure, I'd love for it to last forever, but I'd settle for just once.

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AWARD HISTORY

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